

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Illuminated: A Cinematic Journey to Deeper Spirituality

To Step Into Our Own Shoes
February 2nd, 2025



"Atmospheric Effects I" by Alma Woodsey Thomas, 1970

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert
TBD

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

A Litany of Hope

First Kids First & Youth

In a time when the forces of division abound,
we have dared to come together on this day.

We come together because our love for God inspires it;
our commitment to humanity insists upon it;
and what we can learn from each other requires it.

In spite of our differences,
we share many principles which spring forth
from the teachings of our faith traditions:

A conviction of the fundamental unity of the human family
and the equality and dignity of all human beings.

A realization that might is not right;
that human power is not self-sufficient or absolute.

A belief that love, compassion, selflessness,
and the force of inner truthfulness and spirit
have ultimately greater power
than hate, enmity, and self-interest.

A sense of obligation to stand on the side of the poor,
the hungry, and the oppressed, and to serve
the cause of justice.

A profound hope that good finally will prevail.

*Today, we affirm our commitment to journey together
as a unified force and as a symbol of what life can be,
when we live together in the diversity
the Creator dreams for all creation.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Let Justice Like Waters Roll Down

ST. DENIO

Let justice like waters roll down on our land;
Help us, O Christ Jesus, to join in your plan.
Let righteousness like ever-flowing streams rise;
Come, fill and anoint us, O Spirit most wise.

Pure wisdom and justice flow forth from your hand;
With you as our guide evil forces disband.
Give us, O Christ Jesus, the grace to prevail
O'er systems and powers that keep captives held.

Come now, O Christ Jesus, with blessings and peace
To calm us and stir us, our visions release,
Good News for the poor and fresh sight for the blind;
Your voice calls us on the oppressed to unbind.

O may we flow freely like waters and streams
To heal and restore broken hearts and lost dreams.
Awaken us fully to all we can be,
Reclaiming our souls as we set people free.

-lyrics Jan Alredge-Clanton, adapted

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Sometimes, God of Life, we do things that make it hard
for the best of life to live among us.
We crush it with our lack of hope,
we fail to affirm it when we see it begin to grow in its fragility,
we destroy it with exploitation and injustice,
we can't image it coming from some people,
or we fail to give it support,
because our own life is hard and we resent it in others.
Forgive us when we make it hard for life to live, O God.

Silence

But this morning we affirm God, that, in the Christ,
life does rise from the depths of our failures, our pain, and our grief.
We give thanks to you, God, that this life is never defeated but that you are
always and forever calling us to move into the future with you.
In this time, let us look carefully at you, let us look carefully at each other
and let us see all the resources and gifts which
contribute to life all around us.

And then, O God, help us see how opening our hands and our hearts
will allow your life to grow within us and among us.

***We pray this in remembrance of the way Jesus the Christ lived and loved.
Amen and Amen.***

***Introit**

"A Change Is Gonna Come"
Christin Byrdsong, *Soloist*

SAM COOKE

***The Lord's Prayer**

Judge Bob Ward

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

There is no greater service
that we offer than to heal the sick,
to clothe the unclothed,
to find water for those who thirst,
to bind up the broken-hearted.

*Much is asked of us only because we know, in our depths,
that we are capable.*

As we fill ourselves with the gifts of peace and hope in this hour,
may we fill our hearts to overflowing with an urgent need
to do the work to which we are called.

*On this day, may we overflow in our zeal for a realm of justice and peace,
and equity for all.* [gvosper]

This morning, may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Readings from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

Judge Bob Ward

from the Gospel of Matthew

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

O Holy One,
our prayer is a hunger for wholeness, an insatiable
appetite for completion, a sighing for coherence.

What is easy to forget
is that you are the Desire of our desires.
You burn within us as the intuition of greater
freedom, of deeper meaning,
of a brighter future,
for us, our families, our communities,
and our world...

Today, we honor this 'blessed unrest,'
this 'divine dissatisfaction,'
as your *very* image
that flared in Jesus,
leaving him no place to rest his head or heart.

With this growing understanding,
together we open now to the Spirit's fierce
push and pull of the possible.

*On this day, with one mind and one heart,
we give thanks
for Spirit-sighs that sound in us,
an unspoken utterance of yearning
that angels decipher
and translate into choruses of praise.*

[bsanguin / marthagraham / andrewcohen]

On this day, may it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"Azure"
Katelyn Dietz, Soloist

DUKE ELLINGTON & IRVING MILLS

Sermon

To Step Into Our Own Shoes

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

“The Last Words Of David”
Cathedral Choir

RANDALL THOMPSON

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator’s praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

For your goodness, O God, boundless and everlasting,
for your generosity, gracious and wise,
for your mercy, strong and free,
we give thanks to you.

Let us share your goodness.
Let us practice your generosity.
Let us live your mercy so that we and the world may be well.
In the name of the Christ we pray.
Amen and Amen!

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words for the Journey

Rev. Lehman

We dedicate our lives, God of Love.
Send us to work with you, where your love needs to be known.

*We open our hearts, Spirit of Life.
Take us where life needs to be recreated and shared.*

We offer to you, God of the Way,
our feet and hands.
Lead us to new paths, mature hope,
full of dreams and visions,
that we may enjoy the company
and the encounter with others.

*We pray, God of Love and Life,
sustain us with your hope,
renew us with your strength,
encourage us with your presence,
and embrace us with your grace,
today and every day, forever.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"There's A Spirit Of Love In This Place"
Cathedral Choir

MARK A. MILLER

***Hymn for the Journey**

There's A Spirit Of Love In This Place

MEDEMA

There's a spirit of love in this place,
There's a spirit of love in this place.
You can't see it, but it's there, just as precious as the air.
There's a spirit of love in this place.
O Alleluia, sing alleluia!
We bless your holy name, we bless your name.
O Alleluia, sing alleluia!
There's a spirit of love in this place.

There's a presence of peace in this room,
There's a presence of peace in this room.
In God's tenderness is found peace that passes human bounds.
There's a presence of peace in this room.
O Alleluia, sing alleluia!
We bless your holy name.
O Alleluia, sing alleluia!
There's a presence of peace in this room.

-Mark A. Miller

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence
WACHET AUF (Karl Karow)

Inside The Music

"In February we have the privilege of honoring Black composers in our services. I am personally excited to get to experience Mark Miller's focusing musical presence together with everyone in the closing hymn "There's A Spirit Of Love In This Place." For those paying attention, you'll recall that Miller also composed the meditation anthem from last week, "God's Got The Whole World." He is a powerful voice for peace and justice in the world, a professor at Yale, and a prolific composer and music leader. As Malcolm X's life was full and complicated, so is the music today. We open with Sam Cooke's "Change Is Gonna Come." It is a piece toward which I have immense humility. Cooke's powerful distillation of injustice rides on the compassionate tones of his carefully crafted melody. The opening phrase of the verse reflects the emotional binds of injustice. In the first full bar, the melody stops and ruminates, caught, as it were, in its state of unrest before releasing quickly into the air. This push-pull continues in varied ways throughout the piece such that each time "It's been a long time coming" arrives, we feel release. He doesn't give us a full release, but, masterfully, one tempered by what will be the next obstacle. Cooke left us with an anthem of his time that bears the unique marker of being an anthem for all time. Duke Ellington's "Azure," made famous by Ella Fitzgerald, like "Change Is Gonna Come," was chosen by Spike Lee for his film on Malcolm X's life. On the surface, "Azure" is a song of the unrequited lover. Like all music that speaks to our hearts, the layers it inhabits go far beyond that surface. The color "azure" is a bright blue, like a cloudless sky. Ellington creates a playful rocking in the accompaniment that calls forth a sun-filled walk down a garden path. His melody wanders easily

around that path, almost floating away like water vapor at times. The story speaks to the happy listlessness of believing in our loveliest dreams. Malcolm X had hopeful dreams for himself and the people whose cause for justice he championed. I love this piece for today because it reminds us that the causes we hold dear don't always have to be accompanied by a fight. We can let them live in the tender, child-like places of our souls too. For the offertory we sing Randall Thompson's "The Last Words Of David," with words from 2 Samuel: 23. It has always been a favorite of mine for the ways in which Thompson encourages us through the music to consider the weight of our influence on others. David was speaking to kings and other rulers from a place of significant authority at the end of his life. The line immediately preceding the words that Thompson set are "God spoke to me." People were listening. The only directive that David offers to those coming after him, as spoken to him by the voice of God, is to *be just*. He said: "He (they) that ruleth over men (all people) must be just." Thompson surrounds that statement with appropriate emphasis. Sweeping scales in the accompaniment open into pulsating fortissimo chords in the choir. The final statement of "just" includes a *sforzando/piano/crescendo* to be sure we hear it. In Thompson's mind, this was a rarified statement that lands as difficult today as it did in the 10th century BCE. The rest of David's words, though, are a description of what justice will feel like. Thompson follows suit with some of the most lush and sweet music written for choir. You can hear the compassion dripping from every note. I wanted to sing this piece today to remind us what the hope for justice can feel like as we wade through our current political climate. I also enjoy considering what motivated Malcolm X as a leader. I have no specific way of knowing, of course, though, it seems like from what I do understand, that he might have described justice in a similar way. He had mountains to climb during his life that ended tragically in the name of justice. He carved spaces for people to hope and find solace as he gave voice to the cause of justice. We all have the capacity to influence the scales of societal justice in our ways. I look to these leaders in music, politics, and social movements for example as I seek my place in the struggle." ~ Dr. David Harris